

Civilian casualties

The indiscriminate nature of the violence generated by search-and-destroy was ripe for tragedy. Combat efforts against NVA regulars resulted in battles between well-prepared foes, but operations against Viet Cong insurgents yielded frequent civilian casualties. It was difficult to distinguish ordinary civilians from insurgents, whose family homes were often in contested areas. The creation of “free fire zones”—from which all friendly forces had ostensibly been cleared—enabled US commanders to bomb and shell areas thought to contain enemy combatants with impunity.

Command emphasis on the body count, as well as concern for American casualties, led to indiscriminate violence against Vietnamese people. Even when villagers suspected of having Viet Cong sympathies survived a search-and-destroy attack, they often endured forced relocation or watched helplessly as their livestock, rice stores, and homes were destroyed. These encounters encouraged support for the insurgency among those affected. They also left many American soldiers questioning the efficacy and ethics of the war they were charged with fighting.

Search-and-destroy proved controversial over time. While US forces succeeded again and again in seizing territory and inflicting higher casualties on the enemy than they endured themselves, American strategy failed to yield political results. The morale of the insurgents withstood such attacks, and the infiltration of North Vietnamese soldiers and supplies increased. American efforts to support the South Vietnamese military and take the war to the enemy also encouraged ARVN dependency on the United States, making American withdrawal more difficult.



Year	Number of American combat deaths
1965	1,369
1967	9,378